

Getting to the Point in Good-News and Neutral Messages

Chapter 7

Good News and Neutral Messages

- At work, you mostly deal with neutral messages and good news
- A message that receives the favorable response from the reader is called a good-news message and a message that receives neutral reaction is called a neutral message
- A lot of communicators fail to successfully organize good news and neutral messages
- To succeed, follow effective plans and strategies

Types of Organizational Plans

- There are two types of organizational plans
- Direct Plan
- Indirect Plan



How to Decide on the Plan?

- A good beginning is to assess readers' probable reaction
- Positive or neutral reaction should invite you to adopt the direct plan
- Negative reaction should invite you to implement the indirect plan

Direct Plan

- You communicate the message directly
- You get to the point right away
- You have direct questions or answers
- As such, appropriate for good or neutral news



Examples of Good-News and Neutral Messages

- Routine enquiries
- Thank-you messages
- Direct claims
- Grant adjustments

Routine Enquiries

- Involve asking questions
- Involve giving answers

The General Direct Plan for Routine Enquiries: Asking for Information

- Direct plan contains 3 sections-
 - Beginning with the Objective
 - Covering the remaining of the objective
 - Ending with goodwill



Beginning with the Objective

- There are 2 types of beginnings

1. **start with a direct question and don't ramble around**

Example: *Could you please send me the entry requirements information about the MBA program?*

2. **With a brief statement to orient the reader, followed by the question**

Example: *The one-year extensive MBA program you advertised on June 19 seems like a great opportunity for me. To help me decide on the program, could you please provide me information about the entry requirements?*

Beginning with the Objective (cont.)

- Previous examples are concerned with one piece of information
- What happens if you need multiple pieces of information at the same time?



Beginning with the Objective (cont.)

- Get into the question right away
- Involve asking the broad question to begin with
- This broad question will set up other questions you need to ask in the following section (remaining part of the objective)
- Example:

*Beginning with the objective: Could you please send me **further information** about the MBA program you advertised on The Guardian on June 19? (A broad question)*

Remaining of objective/ body: will set up other questions

Covering the Remaining Part of Objective

● *Other questions (derived from the objective of previous example)*

1. What are the tuition fees?
2. How do I need to make the payment?
3. Are there any scholarship opportunities?
4. Can I undertake a research project?

Covering the Remaining Part of Objective (cont.)

● How to establish the questions?

- Don't combine two or more questions in the same sentence.
- Emphasize on each elements separately
- Split up the sentences using a bullet (e.g. □)
- Have separate paragraphs if you have to explain the question
- You can rank the questions (*e.g. by using numbers 1,2,3, etc. or letters a,b,c, etc. or by using words first, second, third, etc.*)
- Focus on true or solid question form

Don't: It would be really nice if you could tell me.....

Do: Will you please tell me

Ending with Goodwill

- End the message with appropriate friendly comments
- A closing such as “Thank you” or “If you need further information, please don’t hesitate to ask” is polite but they are conventional and clichés
- Use a closing that is tailored

Example: If you will answer this question about the MBA program, I can send the application form before you get busy with admission tests

- Don’t use vague expression (e.g. as soon as possible, at your earliest convenience) while closing the message

Example: Asking for Information

Dear Mr. Ian Heywood:

I saw the advertisement for the Edinburgh MBA program that you posted a week ago on The Guardian. I am interested, I would like additional information

Specifically, I would like to know the tuition fees, accommodation fees, scholarship opportunities, research activities and other information you think relevant.

If the information you give me is favorable, I will undertake the program. Please get back to me as soon as possible.

*Sincerely,
Kenneth*

Features of Previous Message

- Begins slowly
- Writers do not get to the point right away
- There are no true questions
- Gives only the hints for the information
- Didn't end with goodwill
- Ending part is stiff and vague

Your Turn

- Write the message again and establish an effective direct message
- Use the tactics and plans that have been covered so far

An Effective and Direct Message

Dear Mr. Ian Heywood:

Will you please answer the following questions about the Edinburgh MBA program advertised on June 19 on The Guardian?

- *What are the annual tuition fees?*
- *Are library membership, printing and gym membership included?*
- *Is there any scholarship opportunity for Bangladeshi students?*
- *How much do you charge for accommodation facilities?*
- *Are utilities included?*
- *Can I conduct a research project whilst doing the program?*
- *What are the areas of research?*

I look forward to learning more about your MBA program. I hope to send the formal application to you by June 26

*Sincerely,
Kenneth*

Identify the Message Being Answered: Give Information

- Begin with the Answer
- Logically Arranging the Answers
- Skillfully Handling the Negative
- Considering Extras
- Closing Cordially

Begin with the Answer

- Directness is prioritized
- Begin by answering
- What happens if you have more than one answers?
- Involve telling you are giving the readers what he or she is looking for- Example: *Here are the answers to your questions about the Edinburgh MBA program*

Logically Arranging the Answers

- You have little to do if you answer one question
- You should order the answer logically when you have a series of questions to answer
- Good communicator should number the answers, especially if the reader numbered the questions

Skillfully Handling the Negative

- How to handle the negative elements?
- Recall the strategies

Skillfully Handling the Negative

- Place the good news first with high emphasis
- Play down the impact of negative words
- Avoid the negative words
- Deliberately emphasize on the positive elements

Considering Extras

- To build good will, you have to consider including extras
- Add some valuable extra pieces of information that the reader didn't ask for
- Extras will help the reader to make the decision and establish a good business relationship with you
- *Example (The Edinburgh MBA)-
Performance of graduates- 95% of our MBA graduates get into jobs within 6 months of graduation*

Closing Cordially

- Ending should be cordial
- Exploit the polite words that fit the case
- *For example, please let me know if you need further assistance in deciding whether the Edinburgh MBA will fulfill your requirements*

Example: Giving Information

Dear Mr. Kenneth:

I have received your message dated June 19, in which you inquire about our MBA program. I want you to know that we appreciate your interest.

In response to your questions about scholarship, tuition fees, I regret to inform that the scholarship is not available at this moment and the program will cost you £27,000. With regard to accommodation and research work, we don't provide student accommodation facilities and research project can be undertaken by the end of the program.

Please send your application before I get busy with the admission tests and interview.

Sincerely,
Ian Heywood

Features of Previous Message

- An indirect and ineffective response
- It continues to delay the answers
- While answering, the message emphasized on negative elements
- Effective extra pieces of information didn't appear
- The ending was not cordial and the writer was in a hurry

Your Turn

- Write the message again and establish an effective direct response

An Effective and Direct Response

Dear Mr. Kenneth:

Here are the answers to your questions about our MBA program.

- *The annual tuition fees are £27,000 which can be paid in 3 installments.*
- *Yes, the tuition fee covers the library membership, printing and gym membership.*
- *The scholarships are unavailable. However, you can try Commonwealth scholarship which is available in Bangladesh.*
- *Student housing facilities are located close by and they will cost you around £120 per week. We are aiming to establish our own hostels by next year.*
- *Yes, all utilities are included in the weekly rate.*
- *Yes, you can undertake the research program in the areas of HRM, Strategic Management, Entrepreneurship and Leadership.*
- *You will be glad to know that 95% of our MBA graduates get into work or further education within 6 months of graduation.*

Please don't hesitate to get back to me if you need further assistance in deciding whether you will undertake the Edinburgh MBA program. Good luck with the application in advance.

*Regards,
Dr. Ian Heywood*

Features of previous message

- Very direct and effective response
- Gets to the answers right away
- Play down the negative elements
- Emphasize on the positive elements
- Exploiting the extras

Building Goodwill with a “Thank-You” Message

- Acknowledgements are sent to let people know who order goods know the status of their orders
- Communicate when the goods are being shipped
- Many companies use a generic form or computer generated messages
- Individually written acknowledgements are sometimes justified
- An effective acknowledgement not only acknowledge the order but also establishes goodwill

How to Establish the Acknowledgements

- **Step-1: Objective**

- Get to point right away
- Begin with good news- the products are being shipped/ dispatched
- Don't ramble around and waste the words

Good example- The iPhone 6 you ordered on June 25 should reach you by Wednesday. It is leaving our Aberdeen store today by Royal Mail first class

How to Establish the Acknowledgements

- You can also start with a warm expression of thanks

Example- *Thank you for placing your very first order on June 26. The item should reach you by Wednesday. It is leaving our Aberdeen store today by Royal Mail first class*

- **Step-2:** Remainder of the message/ body: Except when some of the good ordered must be delayed, the remainder of the message must be devoted to goodwill building
- **Step- 3:** End on a goodwill note as well

Tact in order acknowledgement

- Sometimes you are unable to send the acknowledgments right away
- Use the direct approach when delays are routine and expected and don't create a serious problem
- It is worth minimizing the negative news
- Use positive words and focus on what you can do

Example- Don't: *We cannot ship the iPhone until the 9th*

Do: We will rush the iPhone to you as soon as our stock is replenished by a shipment due June 29

Tact in Order Acknowledgement (cont.)

- What happens if you have received a vague order?
 - Don't accuse the reader for supplying with insufficient information
 - You should request the information you need

Example- Don't: *You failed to specify the color of the iPhone 6 you want*

Do- So that we can send you precisely the iPhone 6 you want,
please check your choice of colors on the space below

Examples

Dear Mr. Anderson,

Your April 4 order for £539 worth of iPhone 6 has been received. We are pleased to have this order and hope that it marks the beginning of a long relationship.

As you have instructed, we will bill you for this amount. We are shipping the goods by Royal Mail first class.

We look forward to your future order.

Sincerely,

Features of the previous acknowledgment

- It begins indirectly
- To start with, it emphasized the receipt of the order
- Although it intended to produce goodwill, the second sentence further delays
- We-emphasis instead you-viewpoint



Your task

- Establish an effective acknowledgement
- Use the techniques that have been covered so far

Example

Dear Mr. Anderson:

*Your selection of iPhone 6 was shipped today by Royal Mail first class and should reach you by Wednesday (**direct/ to the point right away**). As you requested we are sending you an invoice for £539, including sales tax.*

Welcome to Aberdeen Apple Store. Our representative, Mr. Smith will call you from time to time to offer whatever assistance he can. He is a highly competent technical adviser on Apple Products, especially iPhones.

We will do our best to give you the most efficient service. And Apple family will continue to develop more innovative products in the future.

We genuinely appreciate your order, Mr. Anderson. We are determined to serve you well in the years ahead.

Sincerely,

Direct Claims

● Step 1: Begin with the claim

- Open with a direct claim
- A polite but direct statement
- Should appear at the beginning

Example- Please adjust the invoice (#6379) for our May 10 order to remove the £ 5 shipping charge

● Step 2: Move to an explanation

- Should provide the reader with relevant information

Example- Because our order totaled £70, we are able to take advantage of your offer for free shipping on orders of £50 or more and shouldn't have been charged a shipping fee.

Using Directness for Claims (cont.)

- Step 3: End with a goodwill closing

- Your close should end with an expression of good will

Example- Please send a correct copy of the invoice to me at

jsmith@americanmortgage.com. We look forward to continued business with National Office Supplies.

Examples

Dear Mr. George:

As you know, we have been purchasing your products for 10 years. We have always depended on you for quick, and accurate service, which, unfortunately, looks like it didn't happen this time.

You can imagine how shocked I was when I opened the the order expecting masks and goggles but found gloves and half of the masks I ordered. I was also surprised to see a bill that was £100 more than I planned.

I tried to call you, but you didn't answer, so I left a voice message. I am guessing you want to fix this quickly, so please call me or email me and let me know what your are going to do. If my employees do not have masks and goggles by tomorrow, employees can't work, and we will have to shut down our production line, which will cost us a lot of money. This was a disappointing service and I'm pretty sure it won't happen again, as you have been always accurate in the past. We would perhaps hate to think that we need to go with a different supplier. Thank you.

Alex

Feature of the messages

- The message starts very slowly with an explanation of the situation
- The first paragraph doesn't describe the problem
- There wording here is clear but too much strong
- The words are angry and insulting
- Leaves a bad final impression



Your task

- Organize and establish the direct claim
- Use the techniques that have been covered so far

Direct approach

Dear Mr. George,

Please send 50 safety goggles and 100 face masks, as well as a new invoice, to replace the incorrect order that arrived this morning

On Monday, I placed the order for the safety goggles and face masks, but today I received only 50 face masks and 15 boxes of safety gloves.

If you send the order today, we should receive it tomorrow. Our employees need the safety equipment in order for us to keep the production line running.

Please let me know how you want to handle the return of the order. Thank for your cooperation and outstanding business.

Alex

Adjustment Grants

- Step-1: Start with the good news
- Step-2: Move to an explanation
- Step-3: End with the goodwill closing

Consider Special Needs

- **Need to overcome the negative impression**

- Place yourself in the shoes of the readers
- In the opening you can do more than just giving the affirmative answers

Example- The enclosed check for \$90 is our way of showing you that your satisfaction is our top priority

- Don't recall the actual situation. Your reader is aware of it
- Avoid negative words such as mistake, trouble, damage, broken, problem, difficulty and loss
- Should you apologize? You can apologize and risk the negative effect

Example- we sincerely regret the inconvenience....., we are sorry to know that.....

Consider the Special Needs (cont.)

- **Need to regain the lost confidence**

- First correct the problem right away
- Tell your reader what has been done as convincingly and positively as you can
- If what went wrong was a rare and an unavoidable situation, you should explain it
- You can also tell how the product should be used
- All in all, you should be truthful, professional and reader focused

Example

Dear Mr. Asif:

We have received your May 1 claim reporting that our shipment of Old London lamppost lights reached you with 17 broken units. We regret the inconvenience and can understand your unhappiness.

Following our standard practices, we investigated the situation thoroughly. Apparently the fault is the result of an inexperienced temporary employee's negligence. We have taken corrective measures to ensure that future shipments will be packed more carefully.

I am pleased to report that we are sending you replacements today. They should reach you before the sale begins. Our driver will pick up the broken units when he makes delivery.

Again, we regret all the trouble caused.

Shahriar Hasan

Features of the message

- Indirect approach
- It didn't start with the good news
- Apologizes twice and risk the negative effect
- A lot of negative elements
- Recalling the situation again and again

Your task

- Establish a direct message in order to overcome the negative impressions and regain the lost confidence

Direct Approach

Dear Mr. Asif:

Seventeen carefully packed Old London lamppost lamps should reach your sales floor in time for your Saturday promotion. Our driver left our warehouse today with instructions to special deliver them to you on Friday.

Because your satisfaction with our service and product is important, we have thoroughly checked our shipping procedures. It appears that the shipment to you was packed by a temporary employee who was filling in for a hospitalized veteran packer. We now have our veteran packer back at work and have taken measures to to ensure better performance by our temporary staff.

As you know, the Old London lamppost lights have become one of the hottest products in the lighting field. We are confident they will contribute to the success of your sale.

*Thanks,
Shahriar Hossain*



Thank you!